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Caste and internal labour migrations: Exploring subaltern social geographies in Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger*

Swatee Sinha

Department of English, West Bengal College Service Commission, Swami Dhananjoy Das Kathiababa College, Bankura, India

ABSTRACT
This article examines the critical problematics of caste-based labour mobility in post-liberalization India through Aravind Adiga's (2008) *The White Tiger*. Drawing on Thomas Nail's philosophy of social kinesis or movement, it interprets the caste–class paradigm as a "kinopolitical" formation in which power operates through regulated regimes of mobility. As an alternative to the kinopolitics of caste and class, the article turns to Nail's concept of subaltern social "pedesis"—a form of movement emerging from the foot of the displaced worker—to explore subversive modes of labour mobility. Exemplified through Balram Halwai's migration from a rural agrarian economy to an urban, industrial sphere of casualized labour, the analysis shows how pedetic forms of movement, shaped in this case by the lived experience of caste, may culminate in a kinetic assertion of agency against entrenched social hierarchies, inaugurating a novel pathway of upward mobility.

KEYWORDS
Subaltern labour migration; caste; class; kinopolitics; social *pedesis*; Aravind Adiga

Introduction: The caste–class nexus in Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger*

This article examines caste based-labour mobility in post-liberalization India through the lens of Aravind Adiga's (2008) *The White Tiger*. Drawing on Thomas Nail's (2016) theorization of social kinesis, which conceives social life as a dynamic field of motion, the article conceptualizes the caste–class paradigm as a "kinopolitical" formation in which power operates the regulation, capture, and direction of movement rather than through fixed identities or static structures (24). Raised in the anonymity and deprivation that mark the lives of the rural poor, Balram Halwai, the subaltern protagonist of Adiga's novel, belongs to a caste traditionally associated with "sweet making" in rural Bihar. Scraping a livelihood in an agrarian economy, presided over by middlemen and brokers, Balram's family is displaced from their hereditary caste-based occupation by the steady encroachment of industrialization (Ratti 2020, 229). Consequently, Balram is forced to join the ranks of the emerging class of urban sub-proletariat (Spivak 1993, 78) – a heterogeneous group of dispossessed individuals, absorbed into the informal labour economy. The article draws on the neo-liberal idiom of global finance, entrepreneurial culture, and precaritized labour mobility to reframe the discourse of caste critique

CONTACT Swatee Sinha sinhaswatee@gmail.com Department of English, West Bengal College Service Commission, Swami Dhananjoy Das Kathiababa College, Post Office, Police Station, Bishnupur, Bhara, Bankura, West Bengal 722157, India

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through the shifting dynamics of agrarian labour mobility. Adiga's novel illustrates how, in neo-liberal India, caste is not erased but repackaged as landlords and local zamindars refashion themselves as business tycoons, and the grammar of industrial development is aligned with the grammar of caste – the traditional division of labour in Hindu society.

Against this regime of kinopolitical control that closely adheres to the caste–class nexus, the article demonstrates how the pedestrian movement of the displaced worker, arising from below and propelled by the foot – what Thomas Nail (2015, 125, 223) describes as "pedetic" motion – emerges as a potential challenge to caste-based discriminatory labour politics. Balram Halwai's rise from the ranks of servitude to entrepreneurship exemplifies the subversive power of subaltern social pedesis, by reimagining subaltern labour mobility not as meritocratic, but as enabled through violence and opportunism. As David Huebert (2015) observes, "Balram's relentless desire to achieve success causes him to cling dogmatically to the values of techno-capitalism", which functions as "a quasi-spiritual purveyor of identity" (26). This drive is echoed by Megha Anwer (2014), who speaks of "the raw egotistical and megalomaniacal psychobiology of a beast-man like Balram" (308). Balram's raw corporeal energy – bordering on a predatory animality – aligns seamlessly with the pragmatic politics of neo-liberalism, fuelling his ascent. In remapping caste within the topographic shifts of neo-liberalism, Adiga's novel thus re-conceptualizes the pedetic drive of the migrant worker as a destabilizing force that seeks leverage from an aggressive model of entrepreneurial success, sustained by corrupt state-corporate alliances and secured through political payoffs.

Caste as a social technology and as a kinopolitical arrangement

In his undelivered speech "Annihilation of Caste", B. R. Ambedkar (1936) condemned the caste system for restricting occupational and economic mobility, arguing that it constituted not a division of labour but an unnatural division of labourers (n.p.). In a similar vein, André Béteille (1965) defines caste as a "small and named group of persons characterized by endogamy, hereditary membership and a specific style of life", one that is closely tied to occupations, and their ritual status (46). In the Indian context, caste has historically prescribed occupational roles within a rigid hierarchy rooted in the socio-religious concepts of purity and pollution. The fourfold *varna* system (a hierarchical demarcation where occupation determines class status) delineates Brahmins as priests and intellectuals; Kshatriyas as warriors; Vaishyas as traders; and Shudras as manual labourers, a stratification that curtails mobility across both social and occupational lines.

As the novel demonstrates, these "historically embedded hierarchical divisions" (Salovaara 2022, 968) have not disappeared post-liberalization; rather, they have evolved in tandem with India's mobile labour economy. Caste now demands a "processual" understanding, as traditional boundaries are reconfigured to align with the logic of the market. Caste identities have thus been repurposed, rather than rendered obsolete, generating "new layers" of identity politics (968). Despite liberalization, inter-group disparities persist as employment and wages often continue to mirror caste hierarchies, with lower castes facing limited access to opportunities. This discrimination being "ascriptive" – that is, based on inherited caste identity rather than "achieved" social

status – limits individual agency and hinders social mobility (Thorat and Newman 2010, 3).

Following its independence, India embraced a mixed economy combining state planning with market liberalism. However, the transition was led by upper-caste elites who retained hegemony in both caste and class domains. As Partha Chatterjee (1993) notes, postcolonial development and modernization were shaped by bourgeois interests, which failed to ensure widespread, equitable upliftment (3–4). India's semi-feudal social structure and caste-based occupational segregation left many rural communities trapped in debt and immobility. According to Ruchi Singh (2023, citing Tsujita and Oda 2012), access to land, wealth, and prestige remained determined by caste (138). Lower castes, often relegated to the status of menial labour, faced restrictions in credit access, property ownership, and market participation (Thorat and Newman 2010, 151). Significant educational and economic disparities resulted from these systemic gaps, which were exacerbated by discrimination in the labour market (Singh 2023, 145). To move beyond such static accounts of caste-based exclusion, this article adopts Thomas Nail's (2015, 24) theorization of social kinesis – a sociopolitical framework that conceptualizes society as a kinopolitical arrangement, one in which regulated flows of motion are periodically disrupted by insurgent models of subaltern social kinesis.

The term "subaltern labour" refers to marginalized social groups who are excluded from the socio-economic, political, and juridical spheres by restrictions imposed on social and occupational mobility – restrictions framed from within the rubrics of caste, which functions as an ethnographic marker of identity. Despite its promise of mobility and unfettered economic growth, neo-liberalism primarily benefits the privileged castes, trapping lower-caste workers in exploitative labour structures. Demographic shifts in population due to internal migration are shaped by interrelated forces such as capital accumulation, economic specialization, urbanization, and societal structure (Acharya 2020, 2). These dynamics are further conditioned by the underlying socio-economic junctions of gender, caste, and class that function as a kinopolitics of socially controlled motion.

Nail's concept of "kinopolitics" offers a theoretical and methodological scaffolding for the analysis of social motion as a series of regulated flows and counter-flows, controlled by social junctions or barriers. When a social flow is caught in a circuit – returning to itself like the cyclical phenomenon of debt migration or seasonal migration; that is, "the repeated or seasonal going out and coming back of migrants" (Nail 2015, 30) – it results in the formation of a social junction. Flows passing through a network of interconnected junctions, like the ethnographic index of caste and its allied economic marker class, reinforce a pyramidal/hierarchical structure which imposes restrictions on upward social mobility.

In *The White Tiger* (Adiga 2008), the fundamental regulatory mechanism of caste's social infrastructure is the tightly woven structure of the rural joint family, presided over by the matriarchal figure of Balram's grandmother Kusum. As Balram recalls, "Kusum had decided that I could keep ninety rupees a month for myself: the rest would go straight to Kishan – who would send it straight to her, in the village" (Adiga 2008, 68). In the novel, the debt economy, a direct consequence of the erosion of agrarian caste-based occupations like sweet-making, combines with familial obligations to closely regulate Balram's economic prospects and restrict upward mobility, trapping him within a closed

circuit of movement. Balram's social ascent in class mobility depends on navigating and subverting the caste-coded junctions that constrain the movement of subaltern labour; these social junctions or mobility inhibitors guided by intergenerational, hereditary occupations permit the passage of some flows while cutting short or restricting others (Nail 2015, 24). The operative dynamics of the caste–class paradigm regulating labour mobility are reimagined in the novel as a dynamic terrain shaped by migration, economic transformation, and systemic inequality.

Neo-liberalism generates expulsive socio-economic forces that eliminates agro-based rural occupations to create the "vagabond", "nomad", "barbarian", and "proletariat" – figures whose movement is dictated not by individual agency, but by expulsion and constraint (Nail 2015, 125). The various mobile subject positions identified by Nail – the "floating population", "the stateless", "the lumpen proletariat", "the immigrant", "the refugee", "the vagrant", "the undocumented" wage earner (11) – highlight how immigrant labour experiences social expulsion, dislocation, and "dispossession" at the territorial, political, economic, and juridical level. However, the marginalized peasant, the social outcaste, or the disenfranchised labourer can reclaim their "pedetic" drive as a form of "self-transport" or self-navigation thereby resisting the empirical conditions of systemic impoverishment (125). This resilience, the article argues, leverages on the unbreakable biopower of subaltern worker's pedetic drive, culminating in a politics of non-compliance and social turbulence that unsettles the dynamics of caste-based labour mobility.

Subaltern social pedesis: Rethinking mobility, agency, and resistance

Against an exclusionary politics of mobility – guided by a kinopolitics of caste and class – the pedetic motion of the migrant worker, as "the force of the foot – to walk, to run, to leap, to dance" (Nail 2015, 125), becomes the driving force behind an insurgent model of subaltern social kinesis. The term "pedesis" – which is derived from the Greek word for leaping or jumping – refers to random or uncontrollable movement like the erratic motion of microscopic particles in a fluid, where new forms of kinetic power that are resistant to social expulsion might exist. Nail employs "pedesis" to illustrate that movement is often decentralized and spontaneous rather than linear or controlled. This perspective allows us to understand change, history, and movement as chaotic and emergent processes rather than structured or deterministic ones, while also recognizing that these processes are directly shaped by the shifting nature of broader socio-economic paradigms.

As a radical form of social kinesis, subaltern pedesis operates outside the conventional trajectories of migrant labour itineraries; it is not predetermined by vertical indices or hierarchical structures of mobility but emerges as an instance of subversive "kinopower" propelled by the embodied experience of caste. Social pedesis as a model of social resistance gathers political momentum through discontent and anarchy, arising out of a history of expulsion predicated on the body of the worker. Unlike movements that can be mapped through fixed transit points, pedetic mobility represents a state of social turbulence "without centre, origin, or ultimate destination" (Nail 2015, 126). This transgressive model of social kinesis, rooted in indignation and vulnerability, leverages the pedetic power of the exploited

worker, positioning the dispossessed figure of the migrant as a key agent of social transformation. These extreme manifestations of social kinesis – which are based on autonomous "self-locomotion" – often emerge in response to systemic oppression. These instances of defiance aim to restore the disenfranchised worker's political, economic, and juridical rights often through unconventional and sometimes violent means that remain visceral in execution. Balram Halwai embodies this logic of pedetic resistance that unsettles neo-liberal narratives of meritocratic mobility; his trajectory from servitude to entrepreneurship does not enact the normative script of aspirational success but subverts it through acts of violence, deception, and defiance. In this sense, Balram's mobility constitutes not a celebration of neo-liberal opportunity, but an insurgent assertion of survival and agency within the strictures of caste.

Balram's rise to power parodies the neo-liberal myth of entrepreneurial success fuelled by industry and merit, a view that is criticized by Michael K. Walonen (2019). Balram's letters to Chinese Premier Wen Jiabao, presented as praise of India's entrepreneurial success, ironically expose deep-rooted systemic irregularities and the criminal logic that underpins capitalism, where corruption and violence drive economic ascent. Balram's so-called exceptionalism, which earns him recognition as the "white tiger" in school, derives not from merit but from his rejection of inherited morality and a critical stance towards system-induced inequality. Ironically, in school he is singled out by the inspector as "an intelligent, honest, vivacious fellow in this crowd of thugs and idiots" (Adiga 2008, 35), embodying the rare attributes of the white tiger, "the creature that comes along only once in a generation" (35). Balram's entrepreneurial self-fashioning, however, leverages on deceit, criminality, and an ultimate act of moral transgression which involves murdering his apparently benevolent master. This act, which he rationalizes as essential to becoming "a man" (318), critiques a system where mobility is enabled through violence, not merit. By keeping an ironic distance, the book reveals the moral void and ingrained structural injustices that lie beneath the surface of neo-liberal success.

Balram's career graph, which is non-linear, exemplifies what Nail calls pedesis, or embodied movement emerging from instability and systemic precarity. Unlike regulated mobility, pedetic motion is erratic, rooted in bodily responses to social expulsion and experiences of precarity. As Neetu Khanna (2020) notes, such resistance, driven by the pedestrian drive of the displaced worker, is enacted through "a constellation of bodily actions and reactions" (2). The subaltern body, denied access to formal corridors of power, becomes the site of an insurgent model of social kinesis – strategically devised to combat a politics of precarity. Balram's act of murder, which channels his rage into alternate avenues of class mobility, becomes a symbolic rupture in the caste-bound labour order. His claim to be "A Thinking Man" and "a man of action and change" (Adiga 2008, 273) affirms pedesis as a radical, embodied challenge to caste-capitalist hegemony, and recognizes the visceral politics of caste as integral to generating subversive models of thought. Balram's narrative, masquerading as an entrepreneurial success manual, therefore reveals the ethical vacuity of a system that rewards ruthlessness and the raw exhibition of power over industry and enterprise. Adiga thus delivers a scathing critique of neo-liberal India, where upward mobility is less a function of merit than of betrayal and moral compromise.

Embodied precarity and the politics of expulsion in *The White Tiger*

In his letters to the Chinese Premier, Wen Jiabao, Balram describes his village, Laxmangarh, in rural Bihar, as a place of "Darkness" (Adiga 2008, 14), where landless labourers endure the tyranny of corrupt landlords. These landlords enforce their dominance through violence, holding fiefdoms, and exercising proprietary rights over the local river, agricultural land, and pasture grounds. They also exact a road tax from local *rickshaw* pullers, amounting to one-third of their earnings. Every essential resource – land, water, and feed for cattle – is monopolized by the quartet of landlords, who exploit both the village's natural resources and economic output. The predatory cohort of landlords harbours different degrees of animosity and sexual aggression, which is inflicted on defaulters who fail to pay the exorbitant taxes (24, 25). Such a community-based regulatory mechanism – leveraging on caste politics, and implemented through social and economic penalties – is further reinforced in the novel through the philosophical elements of Hindu religious practices, which glorified servitude. In his letter to the Chinese Premier, Balram identifies Hanuman as "everyone's favourite god in the Darkness" being "a shining example of how to serve your masters with absolute fidelity, love, and devotion" (19).

This lack of access to opportunities for economic upliftment, low income, and resultant impoverishment prompt a steady migration of rural landless workers to urban industrial centres. Acharya observes that in India more than 80 percent of interstate migrants are "unskilled" workers, belonging to the Scheduled Caste (SC) category who are often victims of debt migration (Acharya 2020, 1). Acharya continues:

> Debt-migration, or inter-State labour migration, usually occurs when impoverished individuals take loans or wage advances from zamindars (landlords) of the same or adjoining villages [...] to cover a medical emergency or a major social expenditure, such as a marriage" creating conditions of "neobondage". (2021, 2)

Balram recounts witnessing men from his village leave their families each year, to migrate to Delhi, Calcutta, and Dhanbad in search of employment:

> Each year, all the men in the village waited in a big group outside the tea shop. When the buses came, they got on – packing the inside, hanging from the railings, climbing onto the roofs – and went to Gaya; there they went to the station and rushed into the trains – packing the inside, hanging from the railings, climbing onto the roofs – and went to Delhi, Calcutta and Dhanbad to work. (Adiga 2008, 26)

He observes a similar trend during his own migration to Delhi as a driver, noting that the roads were congested with buses and jeeps overflowing with passengers, many spilling out of the doors and even riding on the roofs. As migratory labourers, commuting between "Darkness" and Delhi, they would return home before the monsoon season, "leaner, darker, angrier, but with money in their pockets" (26). Balram's letters to the Chinese Premier offer an insight into the relationship between caste, economic hardship, and urban migration, foregrounding the contradictions and tensions within the village economy that propel this migration.

The novel offers a powerful critique of emergent forms of socio-economic segregation in the context of the post-liberalized Indian economy where rigid caste-based hierarchies are supplanted by a stark economic binarism: "Men with Big

Bellies" and "Men with Small Bellies" (Adiga 2008, 64). This collapses the problematics of caste, which operates as an elaborate system of social segregation based on occupational coding, and ethnographic demarcations, into the economic binarism of class, a mode of demarcation based on possession of material assets and wealth (Gajarawala 2013, 142). Urbanization thus does not dismantle structural inequalities, but instead reconfigures them into new forms of economic and social stratification.

Angelie Multani (2012), in her article "From the Zoo to the Jungle: A Reading of Mulk Raj Anand's *Untouchable* and Aravind Adiga's *The White Tiger*", highlights this transition. Multani articulates the supplantation of a well-defined, hierarchized socio-historical grid of segregation – represented by the four *varnas* or castes of the traditional rural agro-based economy – with a politics of class antagonism that defines the highly competitive, post-liberalized, urbanized economy in Adiga's *The White Tiger*. No longer bound by the traditional occupational fixity of caste and evicted from the rural avenues of sustenance, figures like Balram who represent the volatile and precarious mobile subject enter the informal labour market, where they encounter multiple forms of social expulsion, dislocation, and dispossession enacted at the corporeal, territorial, political, economic, and juridical level.

Documenting his journey from the rural hinterlands to the urban slums, Balram describes the village as a place of "Darkness", "where basic necessities such as clean water, a home, money and health are routinely denied by the wealthy, who live up there in the Light" (Adiga 2008, 14). Each election, politicians promised electricity, running water, and reforms to fight malnutrition in the children, but after the elections all they got were defunct electricity poles, broken water taps, and deaths of malnourished children, suffering from various deficiencies (19–20). Balram contends that systemic corruption and the performative nature of electoral democracy prevent any substantive improvement in the rural hinterlands. Further widespread illiteracy, criminalization of politics, fraudulent elections, bribery, money laundering, and booth capturing during elections work together to cripple democratic structures of governance based on individual agency. Balram ironically observes that in a bifurcated India, marked by stark contrasts between the rich and the poor, the underclass speaking of democratic participation is "like eunuchs discussing the Kamasutra" (98), a biting analogy that underscores the hollowness of adult franchise for the disenfranchised (Lochner 2014, 37).

In addition to highlighting the rural economy's failure to provide livelihoods for landless and unskilled labourers, and the apathetic state of educational institutions in these regions, Balram's narrative also exposes the endemic corruption in the public healthcare sector in rural communities. He recounts his father's agonizing death from tuberculosis, a disease that disproportionately afflicts the poor and malnourished. Balram observes that although there is no hospital in his village, "there are three different foundation stones for a hospital, laid by three different politicians, before three different elections" (Adiga 2008, 47). The government hospital, where Balram and Kishan took their father, was in another town, housed in a dilapidated building, where countless ill and injured people were sitting on the floor waiting for a doctor to arrive. Having bribed corrupt politicians to secure the government posts, the doctors neglected the state hospital, while profiting from private clinics. Balram's father died without ever receiving medical attention.

Systemic precarity, volatile subjects, and mobility

Martha Albertson Fineman (2017), in her article "Vulnerability and Inevitable Inequality", argues that as "embodied beings", individuals remain socially embedded within a relational matrix that routinely creates conditions of human precarity through mechanisms of social expulsion and deprivation. This model of the vulnerable or precarious life inherently supports the concept of change and mobility, where the migrant individual is characterized by "continuous susceptibility to change in both [...] bodily and social well-being" (142). This vulnerability is shaped by the evolving infrastructures of the state's "kinopower", with tangible "physical and material consequences" (142). The systemic precaritization of landless labourers' bodies is embodied in the abandonment and degradation of the worker's emaciated form.

Whereas the male members of the protagonist Balram's family had become reconciled to the vagaries of seasonal employment – serving as farmhands, scavenging for work in the fields with the onset of the rains, blackened sickles in hand, or pleading with one landlord or the other – Balram's father, in search of better economic prospects, adopted a novel trajectory of subaltern social kinesis opened up by the rapidly expanding neoliberal economy. Instead of casting seeds, cutting weeds, or harvesting corn and paddy, he migrated to the city, choosing to earn his livelihood independently by pulling rickshaws in Old Delhi, or Nizamuddin. In the novel, the emaciated form of the rickshaw puller, straining against the pedal – "a human beast of burden" (Adiga 2008, 27) – carrying middle-class privilege, with its well-lined pockets and stock of goods, becomes a symbol of the subaltern figure's impaired mobility. The pedetic drive of the emaciated worker is harnessed to an exploitative, semi-feudal market economy.

Balram's graphic description of the marks of corporeal abuse etched on his father's body – "the little depression at the pit of his neck", the spine like "a knotted rope", the clavicle jutting out in prominent relief, "like a dog's collar", the flesh etched with "cuts and nicks and scars" – is a testimony to the physical toll of labour. As Balram poignantly observes: "The story of a poor man's life is written on his body, in sharp pen" (Adiga 2008, 26–27). The subaltern body thus remains tethered to an exploitative labour economy, compelled to endure inhuman feats of physical performance. Against this institutionalized kinopolitics of caste, the novel presents a model of migrant social kinesis shaped by both embodied and embedded differences. Embodied differences refer to the physical abuse inflicted directly on the worker's body, where caste becomes a visceral experience – an "embodied sensibility" (Khanna 2020, 1) that forms the basis for "the transformative potentialities of various visceral states that motivate 'progressive' feeling" (13). Embedded differences, on the other hand, reflect institutionally sanctioned inequities rooted in a relational dynamic of expulsion (Thorat and Newman 2007, 4121). The crushed pedetic momentum of Balram's father regains agency through an intergenerational leap, as Balram's recollection of his father's corporeal deterioration under exploitative labour conditions compels him to redirect subaltern pedesis towards violent avenues of redress against systemic neglect.

As an economic migrant from the rural hinterlands into the metropolitan centre, Balram inhabits a mobile and mutating social plane, where bodies are subjected to shifting forms of exclusion and inclusion. This is elucidated by Sukhadeo Thorat (2010), who draws on René Lenoir's (1979) concept of social exclusion, first

developed in the mid-1970s, as an extension of Gary Becker's (1957) framework of market discrimination. The idea of social exclusion encompasses a range of structural disadvantages faced by certain groups who are denied access to stable livelihoods, secure employment, property rights, credit, land, housing, education, cultural capital, legal equality, and democratic participation. Thorat also cites Amartya Sen (2000), who differentiates between various modes of exclusion, such as when individuals are left out of social and economic relations altogether, and unfavourable inclusion, where they are forced to participate under deeply unequal conditions. Exclusion, according to Sen, may be active – deliberate and enforced through policy – or passive, functioning more subtly through social norms and processes. In its passive form, exclusion can become constitutive of a person's identity, manifesting in a loss of connection with others and an inability to participate meaningfully in community life, thereby deeply impoverishing one's experience of self and society.

Balram is "inclusively excluded" as a daily wage earner and chauffeur, situated at the periphery of the more powerful social echelons; yet he later becomes "exclusively included" (Nail 2015, 26) when he instrumentalizes violence and socio-economic predation, in a laissez faire economy, to become the CEO (chief executive officer) of White Tiger Cabs. Although Balram belongs to the middling caste of the *halwais* and is not subjected to a politics of social ostracization, or disabled by the stigma of untouchability, he remains economically vulnerable, inhabiting a zone of precarity (Ratti 2020, 229). Like other footloose, informal workers – dislodged from traditional agro-based modes of livelihood and relegated to the status of manual labourers, serving more affluent households – Balram belongs to the newly minted class of an urban sub-proletariat. He emerges as a cross-species between the categories of a dispossessed subaltern and a proletariat, sustained through multiple, part-time, contractual employments that reinforce his precarity as a casual labourer.

The metaphor of the "rooster-coop": Psychosocial and economic incapacitation

The defining image of psychosocial and economic incapacitation in *The White Tiger* is that of the "rooster coop", a metaphor of systemic immobilization facilitated by caste-based deprivation of economic privileges. The image of chickens cooped up in slaughterhouses in Delhi, who "do not rebel" (Adiga 2008, 174) despite the looming prospect of imminent death, encapsulates the lack of agency and the attendant state of resignation that defines the predicament of the subaltern worker:

> The greatest thing to come out of this country in the ten thousand years of its history is the Rooster Coop [. .]. Hundreds of pale hens and brightly coloured roosters, stuffed tightly into wire-mesh cages, packed as tightly as worms in a belly, pecking each other and shitting on each other, jostling just for breathing space. (173)

The kinopolitics behind the rooster coop depends on the ability of a coterie of privileged men to groom and indoctrinate the remaining 99.9 percent into a cult of servitude. The process is reinforced by a feudal ideology that upholds caste hierarchies and communal responsibilities, alongside structural disadvantages such as the debt economy and an

inequitable access to resources. Together, these forces create a circuit of immobility at the intersecting junctions of caste and class.

Catherine Bros (2014) observes that while pragmatic determinants of caste – such as economic factors – may undergo change in the post-liberalization world order, material prosperity often does little to "offset the burden of being from a low caste or tribe on perceived social rank" (1411). Bros argues that caste in India operates as the largest determinant of perceived social status, alongside a host of other factors such as income, education, and occupation. The cult of servitude foisted on the lower castes is sustained through an internalization of caste prejudices and long-standing practices of ritual segregation, based on the concepts of pollution and purity leading to "acts of self-depreciation" or a disavowal of agency (1411). Inducted early into this ideology of servitude – based on strongly ingrained caste prejudices – Balram, deprived of basic amenities like electricity and water and denied the opportunity to complete his education, inhabits an agrarian hinterland of perennial deprivation. His mobility is initially curtailed by his economic destitution and unquestioning devotion to a life of rigorous physical toil, mirroring the fate of his community which consists of daily wage labourers struggling for subsistence.

Subaltern pedesis as a visceral politics of resistance

As Nail demonstrates, figures such as the dispossessed peasant, the social outcast or disenfranchised labourer may strive to outgrow the empirical conditions of vagrancy and systemic impoverishment, conditions orchestrated by larger, more powerful social structures by autonomizing and reclaiming their "pedetic drive" which is a form of errant movement (2015, 125). Moving beyond macro-political and economic indices that shape labour mobilities, this article unveils a phenomenon of insurgent mobility as "a rational choice of an individual" (Acharya 2020, 2), and one that emerges from personal histories of oppression. The embodied experience of caste fosters a political awakening and serves as catalyst for subaltern modes of resistance and critique. Such acts of resistance, deeply rooted in a history of corporeal abuse, remain visceral in nature, hinging on the pedetic drive of the dispossessed worker. By foregrounding the embodied dimensions of caste as integral to a visceral politics of resistance, Adiga's novel enables an alternative perspective – one that challenges the discursive and ideological framing of caste solely as a socio-religious institution. The pedetic drive becomes an avenue of radical subaltern social kinesis, leveraging bodily momentum to resist the entrenched caste–class order. Subaltern social pedesis thus emerges as a mode of non-compliance: a powerful physiological resistance that takes the form of disruptive corporeal action rather than simply depending on incremental social mobility.

In *The White Tiger*, Balram Halwai embodies this form of resistance; his rebellion is visceral and defiant, symbolizing a new kind of self-liberation that rejects moral constraints imposed by a system designed to perpetuate caste servitude. Balram's journey from subjugated servant to self-made entrepreneur hinges on his recognition that the politics of the "rooster coop", a model of mass servitude sustained by the willing complicity of the servant class, can be escaped only through ruthless defiance. Early in the novel, Balram identifies himself as "A Thinking Man", thus interlinking his physiological capacity for violence to a mode of cognition, conditioned by the visceral politics of

caste. Balram's singular act of violent corporeality – culminating in theft and homicide – becomes illustrative of an insurgent model of radical subaltern social kinesis that challenges the kinopolitical structure of caste and class. It is what Khanna calls a "physiological reflex" (2020, 28), an involuntary bodily act that subverts the tightly woven structure of caste-based oppression; through this singular act of corporeal defiance, Balram gains both occupational empowerment and class mobility. Khanna's concept of "thinking with the visceral" (4) helps illuminate this moment of liberation as one of embodied critique – where the body, and not discourse alone, becomes the site of insurgent thought and action.

What sets Balram apart from the ordinary run of migrant workers, who flock to Delhi hoping "to find some light" (Adiga 2008, 138), drifting across the city without a sense of direction or purposive action, is his critical understanding of the material history of debt-driven migration. Balram grasps the physiological toll migration takes on generations of subaltern workers, alongside the psycho-affectual conditions of bondage that underpin the caste–class narrative. Balram's ability to dissociate himself from what he identifies as an internalized subservience that condemns the rural poor to a life of servitude and unquestioning toil enables him to formulate the conflict between the rich and poor as an ideological war which he describes as a "ten-thousand-year war of brains" (254), signalling not just class antagonism but a visceral critique of historical materialism's deterministic view of subaltern passivity. He says: "people in this country are still waiting for the war of their freedom to come from somewhere else – from the jungles, from the mountains, from China, from Pakistan. That will never happen. Every man must make his own Benaras" (304). Balram's growing political awareness becomes the catalyst for reclaiming his autonomy – not through institutional reform, but through decisive, self-directed action.

Several key moments push Balram towards the act of homicide. When Pinky Madam, Ashok's wife, accidentally kills a child in a hit-and-run incident, Balram is coerced into signing a confession claiming responsibility for the accident – an incident that makes him realize that his life is expendable in the eyes of his upper-class employers. Later, Balram witnesses Ashok's deepening involvement in political corruption, as he bribes politicians to sustain his family's fortune. These events consolidate Balram's realization that morality is a tool of the powerful, weaponized to perpetuate class and caste dominance. The final turning point occurs when Balram realizes that servitude is cyclical – and "embodied repositories" of oppression "continue to play out recursively" (Khanna 2020, 8), traversing generations, destined to repeat unless radically ruptured. It is in this moment of reckoning that, as he observes Ashok carrying the red bag of bribe money, Balram sees his singular opportunity for escape. His act of murder is not merely personal; it is a kinetic rupture and a weaponization of brute labour power into an act of visceral resistance. Through this violent corporeal intervention, Balram reconfigures the cult of servitude that drives the labour economy into a moment of radical defiance.

This singular act of social kinesis differentiates Balram from the "multitudes of small, thin, grimy people squatting, waiting for a bus to take them somewhere, or with nowhere to go" (Adiga 2008, 138). Through a careful dissection of the master–servant dynamics, Balram can crack open the operative code of the "rooster coop" by carving out a new social consciousness that interrogates the embedded hierarchies of caste and class. His growing sense of scepticism towards corrupt leaders who pay lip service to the

philosophy of socialism, and his loss of faith in juridical modes of redressal, culminate in an act of homicide, following which Balram subtly usurps the identity of his master Ashok and uses the 700,000 rupees that he steals from him to finance his entrepreneurial ambitions. Balram's radical fashioning of a novel ontology of subaltern social kinesis thus remains biologically programmed – rooted in hunger and deprivation, and fuelled by the pedetic power of the dispossessed subaltern worker. The pedetic momentum of the subaltern labour thus becomes the driving force of a transformative social praxis – one that breaks away from cycles of submission and asserts agency through corporeal, kinetic, and ideological disruption.

In this context, Anupama Mohan's (2021) revisionary assessment of the Marxist concept of the lumpenproletariat in postcolonial working-class literature proves particularly salient. Mohan's analysis, which resonates with Frantz Fanon's ([1961] 2007) valuation of unmechanized labour, challenges a purely Marxian understanding of the category of the lumpenproletariat as politically inert and ideologically manoeuvrable. Instead, drawing on Fanon's radical reappraisal, Mohan reimagines the lumpenproletariat as a volatile, yet potent agent of social transformation. Fanon famously identifies this class of marginalized, social underlings as "one of the most spontaneous and radically revolutionary forces" ([1961] 2007, 81), driven by "anger and violence" (Mohan 2021, 228). Mohan builds on this insight to argue that the lumpenproletariat may generate a combustible mix of what she calls powerful "social forces of transformation" (228), emphasizing the centrality of visceral affect in fashioning what might be termed an antagonistic model of subaltern social kinesis – one capable of dismantling psychosocial architectures of caste induced inferiority. In Balram's case, the raw mechanics of manual labour finds an outlet through the pedetic motion of the worker, propelling him to strike against the junctions of caste and class which enforce and perpetuate generational servility.

Fanon speaks of the "psycho-affective" mutations induced by a sustained history of abuse and systemic deprivation that informs the political life of the colony and the postcolony ([1961] 2007, 210, 211). These mutations in turn galvanize a politically charged emotional economy, driven by violent rage that fuels an insurgent politics from below. In the novel, Balram's radical philosophy of subaltern social kinesis, with its threat to the bourgeoisie social order, draws from a dynamic synergy between the raw, inherited pedetic power of his subaltern ancestry, and the kinetic drive of criminalized capitalism – a cynical, amoral force, untethered from ethical considerations. In subaltern studies, the agency of change rarely presents itself as a consolidated act of resistance; rather, as Charu Gupta (2015) argues, it often manifests in the figure of the insurgent worker, who embodies deviant subaltern energy. Such representations generate intimate sites of resistance, where the deviant subaltern worker internally disrupts dominant narratives, "carving out contingent, varied and flexible moments of resistance" (101). These moments, although frequently shaped by personal vendettas, act as potent critique of caste and class hierarchies (101).

Conclusion: Subaltern social pedesis as defiant mobility

The article offers an alternative model of subaltern resistance based on unmechanized kinesis; such a model disrupts traditional labour mobilities, which have been

historically analysed through economic and ethnographic indices alone. Balram's transformation from servant to entrepreneur is not accomplished through sanctioned avenues of education, opportunity, or merit but through a deliberate act of defiance against entrenched structural inequities that offer the poor no legitimate pathway to social mobility. Balram's immediate bodily encounters with precarity and expendability form the foundation of a physiological critique – one that manifests in acts of subaltern social pedesis generating a radical model of subaltern social kinesis. His notion of justice is self-fashioned, emerging outside the purview of legal or moral frameworks sanctioned by the state or society. In embodying the rare and predatory attributes of the white tiger, Balram stakes his claim to an exceptional, if morally ambivalent, ontology of liberation facilitated by the act of homicide. Such an ontology of liberation often works in tandem with the criminal underworld, and involves embracing a life of debauchery and crime as a violent response to the systemic constraints of caste and class. The novel thus advances a social critique of caste, exposing how systemic neglect, inscribed most visibly on the overstrained body of the wage labourer, produces ethical compromises and violent retaliations. Fashioned out of a history of corporeal abuse, subaltern social pedesis therefore relies on the kinetic momentum of subaltern bodies to actively vocalize resistance, reconfiguring labour politics in new and unpredictable ways.

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Notes on contributor

Swatee Sinha is an independent researcher with a doctoral degree from the Department of Humanities and Social Sciences, Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur. Her research interests situated at the intersections of literature and philosophy span postcolonial theory, migration studies, and South Asian literature. Her doctoral thesis examined the concept of desire as a transformative social force in the novels of Salman Rushdie. She is currently employed as an assistant professor under the West Bengal College Service Commission. Her research has appeared in leading international journals such as *Educational Philosophy and Theory*, *Somatechnics* and *Glocalism*.

ORCID

Swatee Sinha http://orcid.org/0000-0003-3963-0459

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